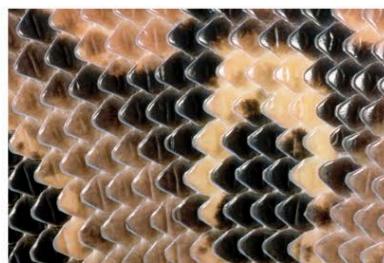


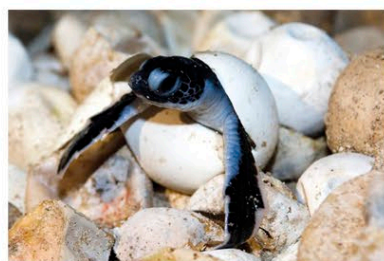
REPTILES

Reptiles are a sophisticated, diverse, and successful group of ectothermic (cold-blooded) vertebrates. Although commonly associated with hot, dry environments, they are found in a wide range of habitats and climates around the world.

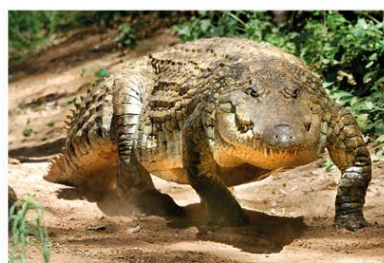
PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	REPTILIA
ORDERS	4
FAMILIES	92
SPECIES	11,050



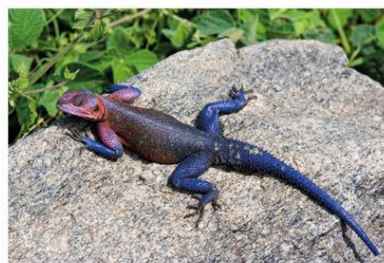
Reptile scales are a protective layer of skin with overlapping patches thickened with keratin and sometimes bone.



The shelled egg allows reptiles to reproduce out of water. The outer layer protects the embryo from dehydration.



Crocodiles can walk with their body raised well off the ground, whereas turtles manage only a sprawling gait.



Reptiles modify their behaviour to regulate body temperature. They bask in the morning sun to absorb heat energy.

The first reptiles evolved from amphibians more than 295 million years ago. They are the ancestors not only of modern-day reptiles but also of mammals and birds. During the Mesozoic Era, reptiles such as dinosaurs, aquatic ichthyosaurs and plesiosaurs, and aerial pterosaurs dominated Earth. Reptile groups that still exist today evolved in this period and survived the mass extinction event that killed off the dinosaurs 66 million years ago.

All reptiles share certain characteristics, such as scaly skin and behavioural thermoregulation – using outside sources to maintain a constant body temperature, by basking in the sun, for example. But the various groups exhibit obvious differences. Turtles and tortoises are protected by a unique, heavily armoured shell. Lizards, crocodilians, and tuataras have four limbs and a long tail. Many squamates, or scaled reptiles – lizards, snakes, and amphisbaenians – have evolved limbless forms.

Hot desert ecosystems are typically dominated by lizards and snakes but reptiles of all types are found in all habitats in the tropics and subtropics. Fewer species are found in cooler temperate climates. Within each ecosystem reptiles are important both as predators and as prey. Most are carnivores, feeding on a wide range of other animals. A few large lizards and tortoises are exclusively herbivores, but many species are opportunistic omnivores.

BEHAVIOUR AND SURVIVAL

Some species are solitary whereas others are highly social. Although sluggish and inactive when cool, once their preferred body temperature is reached by basking or pressing against a warm rock, they can be very active.

Reproductive behaviour can be complex, with males actively defending territories and courting females. Although some squamates give birth to live young, in most cases the male reptile fertilizes the female, who then lays eggs in an underground nest. All reptiles are independent and self-feeding from birth, although some crocodilians give parental care for two or more years.

Reptiles are exploited by humans for their skin or as food. This, along with habitat loss, pollution, and climate change, threatens the survival of many species.

SEA TURTLE IN ITS ELEMENT >

The green turtle may appear primitive but, with efficient flippers and a flattened shell, is well adapted to its aquatic life.

